THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
FOR YEAR 1st OCTOBER 2007 - 30th SEPTEMBER 2008

HELD 15th DECEMBER 2008

The Paris Branch Annual General Meeting was held at 8 rue Boudreau on Monday 15th December, 2008 at 18h30.

There were twenty-two members present with sixteen apologies received which included ten proxy votes.

Apologies : Apologies were received from, : Rev. Mounstephen, Mr & Mrs Zomerplaag, Mme M. Taylor, Mr Humbert Peridi, Mr D. Whitechurch, Mr & Mrs Konirsch, Mr J-P Renouard, Mlle Beth Herwood, Mr P Gautier-Lynham, Mr F Corrigan, Mme Mann, Mr J. Wicker, Mr R. Warby and Mr J-P Liberman.

Exhortation and Silent Tribute : The Chairman invited all present to stand for the Exhortation and to remember those members who had died in the past year.

Minutes of the Previous A.G.M. : The Chairman asked if there were any matters arising from the Minutes that had been circulated to all members. As there none, the Minutes were agreed to be correct, signed and dated as a true record of events. The Minutes were proposed by Mr C. Spencer-Bernard and seconded by Mr J. King.

Chairman's Report : The Chairman started his report by saying that this was a historic AGM, by his calculation the 76th and last to take place in the premises at rue Boudreau. He said he would refer to the property question later in his report.

The Chairman reported that on Welfare we continue to contribute €10,000 per annum to the British Charitable Fund. Our beneficiaries receive allowances totalling approximately 5 times that amount. The Welfare Officer, Mr R. Glen, MBE, has decided to stand down from both Committee and his position as Welfare Officer. Mr D. Bean will take over this position. The Chairman thanked Mr. Glen for his hard work in the past and said that Mr. Glen had said he would continue as a case-worker, we were very pleased to continue to have contact with Mr. Glen. The Chairman said he would like to thank David and Elizabeth Bean for their work as case-workers.

Poppy Appeal : The Chairman thanked Miss Joyce Gilhooley for her hard work in maintaining the Poppy Appeal for us. The Chairman said he would like to thank her team of workers which included Janet Warby, Jim Cockle, George Mutch, and Roné de Beauvoir. Miss Gilhooley reported that so far €8,726 had been counted and banked. Miss Gilhooley said she would like to thank the Secretary for all her assistance, as without this the work would be a lot harder to do.

Ceremonies : The 4th August ceremony was with the participation of the Canadian Minister Plenipotentiary, Mrs Sandelle Scrimshaw. This was followed by a Reception at St. Michael's Church Hall.

Notre Dame 2008 : There was an excellent turnout for the 2008 Service of Remembrance. We thank our Chaplain Rev. Philip Mounstephen for his order of service. Our thanks also to the Rev. David Banbury, Chaplain to the Wessex Regiment (TA). He had just returned from a tour of duty at Basra Airport and his witness was very powerful. Once more we had a strong support from Graham August at the British Embassy, but from 2009 onwards the Embassy will not be sufficiently staffed to contribute to the same level, and we expect to be in total charge of the arrangements at Notre Dame. In this context we have already secured the services of the excellent piper and cornet player who played for us this year. We thank Ken Davey for finding a gem or a piper in Murdoch Macleod. Thanks were also given to our two faithful Metropolitan Police Officers who turn out each year, at their own expense, to be a part of this ceremony. The Chairman said he would like to thank Roger Warby, our Parade Marshal, Janet Warby and David Bean who acted as main usher.

Festival of Remembrance, Royal Albert Hall : On 8th November the Paris Branch was represented at this event by Les Clack, accompanied by his late father's sister and brother who have become branch members. Les's father was killed in the Western Desert.

Ceremonies attended : The Chairman reported that we had attended ceremonies at Maisons-Laffitte on 27th April at the RAF Memorial in the park. We were also present at the Statues of Churchill and de Gaulle on 23rd April in a joint venture with Mémoire et Espoirs de la Résistance, where we laid wreaths at the statues of Sir Winston Churchill and Général Charles de Gaulle. This was followed by a Reception at our Clubhouse.

Pedal to Paris : The Paris Branch was represented at the Annual cycle rally, culminating in the laying of a Poppy Wreath at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier by the National Chairman. The Chairman said he would like to thank Col. Jacir for his assistance with this event.

Battlefield Visit : The Chairman said that this year we had organized an ambitious battlefield visit at the end of September 2008 to Monte Cassino. This was a particularly moving visit where we visited the Polish Cemetery and found the grave of Captain Follit, cousin of our President, Gyles Longley, at Salerno Cemetery and laid a wreath. The Chairman thanked Col Oliver Warman for his stirring commentaries.

Membership : The Chairman reported that our numbers continue to be steady but we would like to have more members. Mailing costs of Branch papers to members are naturally high, so we have started to use e-mail to communicate with members who are connected. The Chairman thanked Mr Mark Yates for his many hours of administrative work.

Social Events since October 2007 : We held our annual Poppy Coffee Morning in the Ambassador's Residence in aid of the Poppy Appeal. We held a 'Thank You' cocktail for Poppy Collectors, Christmas lunch and Dinner events and the Chairman showed a film on conditions in France during the Second World War for the Asociation Internationale at Garches, in April, with proceeds for the benefit of the Paris Branch General Fund. A Franco-British evening had been held at the Ambassador's Residence on 9th December. There were 221 present. This was a joint venture with Mémoire et Espoirs de la Résistance. A series of speeches on the Resistance and the S.O.E., were given. A total of 80 students and schoolchildren were present.

Chess Section : The Chairman said he would like to thank Frank Corrigan for his dedicated leadership with the Chess Section. Mme Corrigan gave a report on behalf of her husband.

Co-Propriété : The Chairman said that members will have read in the Newsletters, that we had negotiated the sale of our premises here to the Maison du Limousin. We expect to sign the Promesse de Vente towards the end of January, beginning of February 2009. The delay is due to a certain legal problem encountered by our Notary, related to the date of our original purchase of this property in 1953. We have started to look for alternative premises which are situated not too far from the main axis of Ligne A of the RER. But we shall not be in a position to commit, until the consideration from the Maison du Limousin had been banked. We will of course continue to keep members informed. The Chairman thanked Mr Jack Wicker for representing us most effectively on the Co-Propriétaires Committee.

House Manager : The Chairman said he would like to thank Mr David Bean for another year of hard work as House Manager. We now have monthly lunches with volunteer cooks providing a wide range of cuisine. Warm thanks to Elizabeth Thorn and Tony Bennett for the cooking of these lunches. Thanks should also go to Roné de Beauvoir for looking after our premises and said that we wish her well in her new home in Monaco.

Fund-raising : The Chairman said he would like to thank members for their faithful support supporting the various fund-raising events we hold each year. The Treasurer appreciates this enormously.

Relations with the British Embassy : The Chairman reminded all present that the Ambassador is our Patron in France, HM The Queen of course remaining our National Patron. Many thanks must go to Sir Peter Westmacott, Air Commodore John Thomas and Wing Commander Graham August for their continued support. John Thomas retired during the year. He has been replaced as Defence Attaché and Air Attaché by Air Commodore Michael Brzezicki, whom we wish well in his new post. The post of Military Attaché has been done away with, and so Brigadier Toby Browne was the last in a long line of Military Attachés who have been good friends of the Royal British Legion.

Branch Committee : The Chairman reported that the RBL in London wishes to standardize overseas branch statutes, and we have been asked to comply with the new model. This represents a lot of work for your officers in the coming weeks, since versions will need to be prepared in both French and English. The Chairman said he would like to offer thanks to our hard-working officers and committee. He said he did not know if the members realize how many hours of voluntary work are put in by our Secretary and Treasurer, and without them this Branch would grind to a halt. He invited those present to show their appreciation in the usual way.

The future : The Chairman concluded his report by informing all present that we look forward to the challenges of the future with confidence. 2009 will doubtless see us in new premises and that will give us a new shot in the arm.

Hon Treasurer's Report : The Treasurer said he was pleased to present to the meeting the annual accounts for the financial year ended September 30th 2008.

Income : For the first time in recent years our expenditure exceeded our income from recurring operations by €1,298, down from last year by €1,467. Our cash flow, however, remains slightly positive and we must not forget that last year we were helped by exceptional income of €1,175. Net fund raising income is down by some €1,500. This is due mainly to Donations and Tombola receipts which are down respectively by €1,683 and €727. Fortunately net income from social events was up by €1,260. Our total cost of operations is at the same level as last year.

Balance Sheet : Our net current liabilities stand at €1,564 and the Administration fund cash position has improved once again with €8,058 in bank and cash balances and a receivable of €679 from the Poppy Apeal Fund. The General Fund has declined to €1,084 at the end of the year. The long-term loan from Entenial stands at €6,003 at the end of the year after repaying €1,691. This loan will have to be repaid when the sale of the premises is finally concluded. The Maison du Limousin has contracted to purchase our premises for an amount of €560,000. It was hoped to conclude the sale in December but there is a significant delay on the part of the Conservateur des Hypothèques who will not be able to produce the required certificates until January.

Poppy Appeal Fund : Donations and poppy sales were up by 48% (€3,937) against a decline of over €3,000 last year. Relief payments made to the British Charitable Fund were €7,500 and other welfare payments of €11,123 were made, of which €10,707 were financed by RBL UK. We show a net excess of outgoings over income for the year of €246, after transferring €3,300 to the Royal British Legion in the UK, and our accumulated funds are down to €3,635.

The Treasurer concluded his report by saying that these accounts, as presented, had been audited.

The Chairman thanked the Treasurer and asked for a proposer of these accounts and seconder. Mr G. Scott proposed and Mr. J. King seconded the motion that the accounts be accepted.

Welfare Report : Mr. Bean reported that in the year under review we have helped four new cases, one of which was on behalf of another RBL Branch. We have seven on going cases and we have passed one case to SSAFA. Eight of our cases are receiving on going help from BCF for which we would like to minute our thanks.

The Chairman gave a vote of thanks to the Welfare team for the hard work put in to process these cases.

Election of Officers & Committee : The Chairman reported that Mr. O.G. Longley, CBE, MC, had agreed to be our Hon. President. The Chairman asked Mr. Longley to read the names of the nominees for the positions of the Officers.

Chairman	**R. Thorn**
Vice-Chairman	**J. Wicker, OBE**
Treasurer	**D. Blanchard**
Secretary	**Mrs J. Warby**

The following were elected to the Committee : Miss J.M. Hicks, Mme N. Riols, Messrs Bean, Cockle, Davey, Edwards, King, Konirsch, Spencer-Bernard and Yates.

The following are invited to be ex-Officio Members on our Committee : Col. D. Jacir, Mr. G. Scott, Mme G. Corrigan and Mme P. Levalleur. Rev. P. Mounstephen is our Branch Chaplain and Mr. C. Fewkes, Auditor.

The Officers were voted into office and the Committee were elected en masse.

Any Other Business : Mr. Bean said he would like to offer a Vote of Thanks to the Chairman for the smooth running of the meeting.

Mr. Bean said that in light of our proposed move, he would like to have all key fobs and keys returned to him from those persons not now needing keys to obtain access to our premises.

The meeting was informed that Mme Michele Mann had now moved to Hazelbrouck in the North of France.

There being no further business, the meeting was closed at 19h20.